

Ian Cowpar

Principal-scope Product Leader · AI-first SaaS · Platform & Adoption · Zero-to-one Builder

ian.cowpar@gmail.com · 351-235-0365 · linkedin.com/in/ian-cowpar · github.com/iancowpar · theunofficialleader.substack.com

SUMMARY

Product leader operating at principal scope inside AI-first SaaS. Builds the internal platforms product teams depend on, ships the working prototype in Claude Code rather than handing the spec over a wall, and measures whether behavior actually changed rather than whether the dashboard moved. Two years owning product across a \$250M ARR enterprise platform serving 300 customers, including the organization's first organized AI capability layer (built from zero, scaled across the PM org without top-down mandate) and a zero-to-one self-serve product taken from concept to production in a one-week prototype cycle. A decade prior at Broadridge in compliance-grade financial services, where client confidentiality and regulatory consequence were the operating environment, not a footnote. Maintains twenty custom slash commands and a personal Claude Code productivity OS in active daily use. Originator of the Zero-Translation Building framework with weekly published thought leadership on AI adoption realism.

SELECTED OUTCOMES

- **Built UKG product organization's first organized AI capability platform.** Scaled shared infrastructure across 20 PMs with sustained voluntary creation: multiple PMs built their own custom slash commands that replaced manual workflows entirely (the deepest adoption signal, observed in practice). No top-down mandate behind the program.
- **Shipped a zero-to-one self-serve product from concept to production in a one-week prototype cycle.** Projected ~30% time reduction in the underlying enterprise workflow and removed engineering from the critical path of a previously ticket-gated process. Wrote the working prototype in Claude Code, partnered with the platform architect to scope across three business epics, delivered an engineering-ready package the architect built directly against.
- **Surfaced ~\$50M in at-risk ARR before escalation** through a composite risk model scoring the top accounts on exposure, case volume, true-defect rate, and Salesforce sentiment. Replaced raw ticket counts with weighted signal, defined the success metric, automated the weekly reporting cadence the program lead acted on.
- **Cut a working defect list from ~200 issues to 5 (~97% reduction)** through an opinionated operational analytics product with a Claude Code function embedded as a first-class feature. Classified open issues across five panels (escalations, defects, internal bugs, CVEs, noise) across four products and routed the single highest-leverage action per panel so engineering acted on signal, not noise.
- **Drove cross-functional prioritization across product, engineering, and services without direct authority** in executive escalation rooms for a \$250M ARR platform serving 300 enterprise customers. Synthesized real customer signal against committed roadmap and translated that into tradeoff decisions across four product lines.

EXPERIENCE

Senior Product Manager · UKG · Lowell, MA · Jun 2024 – Apr 2026

Principal-scope product ownership across AI capability, zero-to-one builds, and opinionated data products serving 300 enterprise customers on a \$250M ARR platform.

- **Built the AI capability platform from zero across 20 PMs**, scaling shared infrastructure with sustained voluntary creation; coached individual PMs into role-specific use cases until multiple were replacing manual workflows with their own custom slash commands. Behavior extinction, not addition. No top-down mandate.

- **Shipped a zero-to-one self-serve product concept-to-production in one week** , projected to deliver ~30% time reduction in a ticket-gated enterprise workflow. Wrote the prototype in Claude Code, partnered with the platform architect on scope decomposition (three business epics: UI, rules, deployment), and handed engineering a delivery-ready package they built directly against.
- **Surfaced ~\$50M in at-risk ARR requiring intervention** via a composite risk model for the top accounts in the enterprise upgrade program; replaced raw ticket counts with weighted signal across exposure, case volume, true-defect rate, and Salesforce sentiment. Automated the weekly reporting cadence the program lead acted on.
- **Cut a working defect list ~97% (from ~200 issues to 5)** through an opinionated analytics product with a Claude Code function embedded as a first-class feature, routing the single highest-leverage action per panel across four products and five issue types.
- **Drove cross-functional prioritization across product, engineering, and services in executive escalation rooms** for a \$250M ARR platform serving 300 enterprise customers, translating real customer signal into tradeoff decisions across four product lines without direct authority.

Brand Champion, UKG North America Regional Lead 2026. Fire Up ERG (women and allies), Business Innovation workstream lead. Designed delivery-health instrumentation across two engineering teams (15-minute refresh, documented anti-pattern criteria for burndown, velocity, story points).

Business Analyst · Broadridge Financial Solutions · Andover, MA · Jan 2014 – Jun 2024

Forty-plus enterprise SaaS deployments end-to-end in compliance-grade financial services, where client confidentiality and regulatory consequence shaped every delivery decision.

- **Led 40+ enterprise SaaS client deployments end-to-end** in a regulated environment where a wrong output had regulatory consequence, not a bug ticket. Partnered with engineering on system behavior, data flows, integration dependencies, and technical tradeoffs.
- **Served as internal subject-matter expert for an omni-channel communication product adopted across the entire enterprise client base** , translating complex compliance capabilities into workflows non-technical buyers could operate without support.

Senior Document Development Analyst · Broadridge Financial Solutions · Andover, MA · Jan 2006 – Jan 2014

Built and maintained complex client-facing document and communication systems in a regulated financial services environment.

SKILLS AND FOCUS AREAS

Product Strategy & Leadership: Principal Product Manager-scope ownership, two-to-three-year product vision, OKR-to-execution, roadmap and prioritization in ambiguous spaces, cross-functional leadership without direct authority, mentorship of junior PMs, recognized subject-matter expert, outcomes over output, Agile / Scrum, B2B SaaS

AI as Core Multiplier: AI capability platform building, embedded AI features inside internal products, Claude Code prototyping, twenty custom slash commands and a personal Claude Code productivity OS in active daily use, agentic workflows, responsible and customer-centric AI judgment, AI adoption measurement (extinction-over-addition, the fallback principle)

Technical Credibility: APIs and system architecture, data flows and integration dependencies, deployment-model and platform product thinking, technical-systems fluency with engineering, requirements engineering, SQL

Data & Experimentation: Opinionated analytics products, composite scoring and risk modeling, success-metric and KPI definition, hypothesis-driven development, qualitative-to-structured synthesis, signal-versus-noise routing

Enterprise SaaS: Compliance-grade regulated delivery, client confidentiality as table stakes, enterprise customer escalation-room presence, multi-org program coordination, executive synthesis, stakeholder management

Tooling: Jira, Confluence, GitHub, SQL, Claude Code CLI, Slack MCP, Salesforce Service Cloud (operator)

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Science, Management Information Systems and Management

Manning School of Business, UMass Lowell · 1999

WRITING AND THOUGHT LEADERSHIP

The Unofficial Leader (Substack) · theunofficialleader.substack.com

Weekly publication on where AI actually earns its place, adoption realism, and what's happening beneath the surface of how teams work. Originator of the Zero-Translation Building framework. Active LinkedIn audience engagement on product strategy, AI adoption, and team dynamics.